

EXOTIC MODE BORROWING

Beyond parallel minor — borrowing from Lydian, Mixolydian, Dorian, and Phrygian modes for specific coloristic effects. The key: only borrow chords that CONTAIN the characteristic note.

THE DARKNESS HIERARCHY — BRIGHTEST TO DARKEST (LEFT TO RIGHT)

LYDIAN brightest #4 char.	IONIAN major baseline	MIXOLYDIAN bluesy b7 char.	DORIAN minor+ nat.6 char.	AEOLIAN natural minor b6 char.	PHRYGIAN darkest b2 char.	LOCRIAN unusable x banned
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The borrowing rule: **Only use chords that CONTAIN the mode's characteristic note.** Chords without the characteristic note add no modal color — they're redundant diatonic chords that don't signal the borrowed mode.

LYDIAN MODE (#4 CHARACTERISTIC)

LYDIAN

"The brightest mode — floating, ethereal"

#4 = F# in C Lydian

II or D7 Most common Lydian borrow. Contains F#. Dual function: Lydian color OR V7/V (secondary dominant). Extremely versatile.
"Forget You" — CeeLo Green (D major chord in C context)

#ivø7 F#ø7 in C context. Darker sound from a bright mode — the tritone inside adds sophistication. Common in jazz-influenced pop.
Jazz standards, neo-soul arrangements

MIXOLYDIAN MODE (b7 CHARACTERISTIC)

MIXOLYDIAN

"Bluesy, rock, party — major with b7"

b7 = Bb in C Mixolydian

bVII / bVIIImaj7 Bb or Bbmaj7 in C. The most immediately recognizable rock/blues sound. Classic Mixolydian borrow — creates a bluesy, non-dominant b7 chord.
"Rock With You" bridge — Michael Jackson

v-7 (nat.9) Gm7 with natural A (9th) — available in Mixolydian because the 6th degree is natural. Softer, more sophisticated than v-7 from pure Aeolian.
"Best Part" — Daniel Caesar

DORIAN MODE (NATURAL 6 CHARACTERISTIC — USED IN MINOR)

DORIAN

"Minor with natural 6 — dark but hopeful"

nat.6 = F# in A Dorian

IV or D7 In Am: D major or D7. The natural 6th (F#) brightens the minor key. Lifts the mood while staying minor-centered. Dorian IV in Am = same as Lydian II in C — same chord, different context.
"Earth Song" — MJ; "What Goes Around" — Timberlake

PHRYGIAN MODE (b2 CHARACTERISTIC)

PHRYGIAN

"Dark, exotic, Spanish — the b2 sound"

b2 = Db in C Phrygian

bII / bIIImaj7 Db or Dbmaj7 in C context. The most exotic, dramatic borrow. Approaches from a half step above tonic. Flamenco, cinematic, dramatic. Use sparingly for maximum effect.
"Children of Sanchez" theme, flamenco-influenced R&B

bVII-7 Bbm7 in Cm context. Dark, descending, cinematic. Used in film scores and dark R&B. Creates a heavy, weighty descent.

"Mix and match: borrowing from multiple modes in one progression creates emotional arcs. A progression might start Lydian-bright, dip into parallel minor darkness, and rise back to Ionian — painting a complete emotional story using the full modal spectrum."